R&AW spy networks are used for more than stealing and defending state secrets. Spies monitor and neutralise drug and money laundering cartels, raise assets for sabotage in countries of interest, engage in psychological warfare and economic espionage, strengthen pro-India elements with the help of financial packages and also keep the Intelligence Bureau and other domestic security and law enforcement agencies informed about potential threats from terror groups and foreign organisations involved in subversive activities. Today, espionage collection by the R&AW is more efficient than it has ever been before.

On the other hand, a cyber security officer in Delhi or Bengaluru can shut down a power plant in Lahore at the press of a button or thwart a cyber attack launched by non-state actors operating in the dark web against vital installations in the country. In the new political landscape of India, digital intelligence, open-source intelligence and HUMINT must collaborate and act as a force multiplier for the government to create better informed policies. Since no single agency can tackle all the threats confronting policymakers today, the R&AW will also have to enhance its partnerships with friendly spy organisations in other countries. But above all, the government will always need a good spy to read the mind of an adversary.

In the late 1990s, the Indian spy agency had provided huge sums of cash to a Pakistani asset to start an Urdu newspaper. Civilian bureaucrats thought this was a complete waste of money. Today, the publication has grown into one of the most potent weapons in the R&AW's arsenal. But there have also been misjudgements. In 2002, the R&AW had spurned an outlaw from the neighbouring country when he sought the money to roll out certain business activities in Africa. The Indian